This book aims not just to reinsert India into the Asian story but also to reinterpret aspects of its China policy and its foreign policy more broadly. The view of China in India was at best a dominant one, but there was never a consensus. China policy was constantly contested within the Indian government and polity. The debate is usually framed as revolving around differences on whether or not China was a challenge. But this book shows that concern about China was more widespread—even Nehru, considered to be naïve about China, believed it would pose a challenge. The key difference was the kind of challenge, and how to deal with it. For example, India's first deputy prime minister, Vallabhbhai Patel, believed China was a geopolitical threat and needed to be confronted with the buildup and use of force, and possibly even alliances. Nehru, on the other hand, mistakenly believed that China would think like India and would seek development at home and peace in its periphery. That meant a geopolitical challenge was some ways off and that India had time. He was more concerned about the threat of ideas and subversion from China in the short term.

Like Patel, Nehru advocated the strengthening of border infrastructure and defenses. However, prioritizing autonomy over capacity building, a greater focus on the Pakistan problem, and a concern about diverting funds from development to defense meant that his government neglected or delayed making the required investments to strengthen itself vis-à-vis China —a lesson that current and future Indian foreign policymakers would do well to remember.

It is also worth remembering, as this book shows, what nonalignment was and was not. It was not merely or even primarily a result of principle, but was driven by pragmatism. It was a strategy that Indian leaders, acting from weakness and operating under political and economic constraints, used to expand their options by diversifying their portfolio of partners and thus their dependence. This was important to Indian foreign policymakers because, even as they sought security and prosperity, they also wanted strategic and decisional autonomy.

The policymakers of a recently decolonized India found themselves facing a geopolitical, economic, and ideological climate that was significantly shaped by the Cold War. Their diversification strategy helped create space in this competitive context. It was not a result of trying to "avoid entanglement,"[9] but of recognition that, unlike the US in its early